



United States
Attorney's Office
District of Rhode Island



Addiction Treatment Center Supervisor Sentenced in Scheme to Defraud Federal, State, and Private Health Care Insurers

Wednesday, March 5, 2025

For Immediate Release

District of Rhode Island

Insurers were billed for more full client sessions than could be provided in a 24-hour day

PROVIDENCE, RI – A clinical social worker nicknamed by her co-workers as the “Five Minute Queen” who, at times, substituted a one or two sentence conversation for a billed 45-minute therapy session for her addicted patients has been sentenced to three years of supervised release, the first three months to be served in home detention with electronic monitoring, announced Acting United States Attorney Sara Miron Bloom.

In pleading guilty in November 2023 to a charge of conspiracy to commit health care fraud, Mi Ok Song Bruining, 64, admitted that, while employed as a supervisor at Recovery Connections Centers of America, Inc. (RCCA) in Providence, she helped devise and execute a scheme that shortchanged Rhode Island and Massachusetts substance abuse disorder patients out of counseling and treatment services while, at the same time, defrauding Medicare, Medicaid, and other health insurers out of more than \$3.5 million dollars.

Bruining, and others working at her direction, routinely submitted false and fraudulent claims for psychotherapy and counseling services that did not occur for the length of time billed, consistently billing for far more patients than was possible for RCCA staff to have seen during office hours. Bruining, known at RCCA as the “Five Minute Queen” for her speed in seeing patients for so-called counseling sessions, billed for 45-minute sessions when she actually saw patients for no more than 5-10 minutes, at times asking patients only one question before she ended a session.

According to information presented to the court, to facilitate this fraud, Ms. Bruining directed counselors and others at RCCA to record in their notes that they were providing counseling in 45-minute intervals,

but without listing AM or PM for the start time. Ms. Bruining gave this instruction so that it was not clear that they were seeing more patients than possible within a single hour. She also instructed other counselors to copy and paste the last visit’s note into each entry to make the bill look complete. As a result, many of the patient notes for patients billed by RCCA were simply identical cut-and paste copies of the same note.

Bruining was sentenced today by U.S. District Court Mary S. McElroy to three years of supervised release, the first three months to be served in home detention with electronic monitoring, 100 hours of community service, and to pay restitution in the amount of \$100,000.

The case was prosecuted by Assistant United States Attorneys Sara Miron Bloom and Kevin Love Hubbard.

The matter was investigated by the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, Office of Inspector General and the Federal Bureau of Investigation. United States Attorney Cunha thanks the IRS, Customs and Border Protection, and the Rhode Island Office of the Attorney General for their assistance in the investigation.

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Updated March 5, 2025

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HEALTHCARE FRAUD

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Press Release Number: 25-24

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